Each of the Chola kings gave themselves grandiose and identifiable names and titles, but their royal wives had to be content with the single generic title of Sembiyan Mahadevi, ‘Great Queen of the Cholas’ – or, if they were very lucky and bore a son who went on to rule, the further title of ‘The queen who had the good fortune to bear King So-and-so’. As a result it is very hard today to distinguish one queen from another whenever their names are set down on dedicatory or donative inscriptions. However, there was one particular Chola queen whose piety, strength of character and, above all, longevity ensured that she would not be forgotten: the Sembiyan Mahadevi who was also known as ‘The queen who had the fortune to bear Uttama Chola Deva [Raja Paratanka II]’, and who further distinguished herself from her peers by describing herself as ‘The daughter of Mala-Peruanadigal’.

By triangulating these three titles, we can identify this exceptional lady as the queen of the Chola ruler who conquered Lanka in 925 CE and the grandmother of the formidable and formidably named Rajaraja (‘king of kings’), which places her as living from about 900 to 980. For more than six decades this Sembiyan Mahadevi was a dominant figure in tenth-century South India, not least as a royal patron of temple-building and donor of bronze images and jewellery. Not only was she extremely pious and extremely wealthy, she was also sufficiently strong to be able to impose her will on her husband, their son and possibly her grandson too, to say nothing of all those Brahmins at court who acted as the ruler’s advisers.

The Imperial Cholas have been credited with reviving the ancient South Indian craft of casting in bronze – more properly, in copper alloy – using the so-called ‘lost-wax process’, which in earlier times seems to have been the preserve of the Buddhists. Our particular queen Sembiyan Mahadevi appears to have been closely involved in this revival, which her descendants further refined and took to even greater heights of artistry.